White Beans in Tomato & Olive Oil (Fasola Ata)

FROM NELL'S KITCHEN

When it comes to fasolya ata, it has to be my mum's version—or mine, made just like hers.

Serves 6–8 · Prep 15 min · Cook 3 h · + overnight

INGREDIENTS

- 500 g dried white beans
- 1 large onion, very finely chopped
- 1 green bell pepper, deseeded and very finely chopped
- 6 tbsp olive oil, divided
- 1 tsp salt, adjusted to taste
- ½ tsp sweet pepper
- 1½ litres plain tomato juice, plus extra as needed
- 1 tbsp tomato paste
- 1 tsp chilli paste, or to taste

METHOD

1. Pick over the beans, rinse and place in a large bowl. Cover generously with cold water and soak overnight in the fridge.
2. The following morning, drain, rinse thoroughly and set aside.
3. Heat four tablespoons of olive oil in a heavy saucepan over medium-low heat. Add the finely chopped onion and salt. Cook gently until softened and translucent.
4. Add the very finely chopped green pepper. Cook for 8–10 minutes, stirring regularly, until both the onion and pepper are thoroughly softened.
5. Add the soaked, drained beans and gently turn them through the onion and pepper mixture for a minute or two.
6. Add the remaining two tablespoons of olive oil, sweet pepper, tomato juice, tomato paste and chilli paste. Stir gently to combine. The beans should be generously covered with tomato juice.
7. Bring to a full boil and maintain the boil for 30 minutes, stirring carefully to prevent sticking and adding more tomato juice as needed to keep the beans submerged.
8. Reduce the heat, partially cover and continue cooking at a gentle simmer until the beans are fully tender inside but still hold their shape. Begin checking after another hour; cooking may take considerably longer depending on the beans. Add extra tomato juice whenever needed.
9. Once the beans are tender, adjust the sauce's consistency: simmer uncovered briefly if too thin, or add a little tomato juice if too thick. Keep the sauce generous, as it will thicken while chilling.
10. Taste and adjust the salt and chilli. Spoon into shallow serving dishes or containers, allow the initial steam to subside and refrigerate promptly. Cover once cooled and chill for at least 3 hours, until cold, before serving.

Tip

Choose good-quality beans. Older dried beans can take much longer to soften, particularly when cooked in tomato sauce.